

UAE : THE KNOWLEDGE ECONOMY



Source: UAE Year Book 2008

Educational opportunities in the UAE have blossomed since the establishment of the federation when only a tiny minority of the urban population had access to formal education. Today, the UAE offers a comprehensive education to all male and female students from kindergarten to university, with education for the country's citizens being provided free at all levels. There is also an extensive private education sector, while several thousand students of both sexes pursue courses of higher education abroad at Government expense.

Although great strides have been made since the educational system was first formalised, a major overhaul of the system to meet the needs of the twenty-first century is a cornerstone of UAE Government strategy, with a particular emphasis on the decentralisation of administration to educational zones. Sheikh Khalifa also issued a federal decree in September 2007 authorising the Cabinet to reorganise the private education system, replacing the private education law of 1999 and bringing the private sector in line with public education. Individual emirates are also reforming their educational systems within the context of the federal framework.

HIGHER EDUCATION

The UAE has established a diversified system of higher education in a very short period of time. UAE citizens can attend government institutions free of charge, and a wide range of private institutions supplement the public sector. Ninety-five per cent of all females and 80 per cent of all males who are enrolled in the final year of secondary school apply for admission to higher education.

PRIVATE INSTITUTIONS

Private universities offer a wide range of tertiary-level opportunities in the UAE. Notable institutions include the American Universities of Sharjah and Dubai, Sharjah University and the Ajman University of Science and Technology. The Ministry of Higher Education and Scientific Research is responsible for the accreditation of institutes and degrees and its website provides a comprehensive list of recognised institutes and programmes. Abu Dhabi University (ADU), with campuses in Abu Dhabi and Al Ain, is one of the newer private institutions. ADU has over 44 nationalities in its student population and is continuously cultivating associations with prominent educational institutions worldwide and offering joint programmes with a large number of international universities. ADU's Dh10 million in grants and financial aid offered to high-achieving students in the form of the Sheikh Hamdan scholarships is the largest programme of its kind offered by government or private higher education institutions in the UAE.

ADU inaugurated its new well-equipped 4-million-square-metre campus at Khalifa City 'B' in October 2006 and signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) in 2007 with Munich Technical University and the University of Bonn from Germany to jointly establish a College for Medicine and Health Sciences to be based at the ADU campus. Al Hosn University in Abu Dhabi opened in 2005. This new private university, supported by Abu Dhabi Holding Company (ADHC), will initially be operating from temporary premises. A large site in Madinat Khalifa has been

earmarked by the Abu Dhabi government for the construction of a permanent campus. As already mentioned, an Abu Dhabi chapter of the Sorbonne University was also established in 2006. Wholly owned by ADEC, the university will award qualifications under French regulations and in accordance with academic standards set by the Sorbonne

in Paris. All subjects will be taught in French by tutors from the Sorbonne. The new university, which is open to students of both sexes and of all nationalities, is operating from an interim campus near the Petroleum Institute, but will move to a permanent home by early 2008. The opening of the Sheikh Mohammed bin Zayed Centre for Science and Technology at the Institute of Applied Technology in Dubai in 2007 further underpins the country's drive towards imparting twenty-first-century skills to students, focusing in particular on generating an elite corps of scientists, engineers and technicians.

Dubai Knowledge Village, a member of TECOM Investments, has launched Dubai International Academic City (DIAC), the world's only free zone dedicated to international higher education. Located in the 2.33-million-square-metre Dubai Academic City, a dedicated tertiary-level multi-university educational cluster, DIAC will serve as the regional base for a number of international higher education institutions, targeting students from the region who are unable to go abroad to study. Nearly 20 international institutes of higher learning from Australia, India, Pakistan, Iran, Russia, Belgium, UK and Ireland have already set up base at DIAC, catering to over 8500 students.

On completion DIAC will be able to accommodate 20 to 30 universities and house between 30,000 and 40,000 students and will be designed to provide a quality of student life and services that is international, culturally diverse and dynamic.

OTHER INSTITUTIONS

In addition to the higher level institutions outlined above, the UAE also has several vocational and technical educational centres for those seeking practical career training. These include the Emirates Institute for Banking and Finance, the Dubai School of Government, Etisalat's colleges and university, Etihad's training centre, The Emirates Aviation College for Aerospace and Academic Studies and the Petroleum Institute (PI).

KNOWLEDGE FUND

Recognising that education is the key to an Arab renaissance, HH Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice President, Prime Minister and Ruler of Dubai has created the UAE-based US\$10 billion Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum Foundation to help build a knowledge-based society throughout the region. The fund, which will be run as an investment trust, will finance educational initiatives and support government projects through scholarships, scientific research, development of teaching staff capabilities and improvement of educational infrastructure. The foundation's programmes are also aimed at enhancing the standing of scholars and intellectuals in the Arab world.